

U-CAN
URBAN COLLECTIVE ACTION NETWORK

COLLABORATION TOOLKIT · PART 1

Are You Ready to Collaborate?

A practical reflection tool for organisations considering collaboration.

WHY THIS TOOLKIT?

Collaboration does not succeed simply because organisations decide to work together. It depends on conditions that enable organisations to learn, adapt and work effectively together.

Drawing on U-CAN's Practice-Informed Framework for Collaboration, this toolkit helps organisations reflect on five signals that can influence their readiness to collaborate.

It is not a test of whether organisations are ready or not. It is a tool to surface different perspectives, identify areas that need attention, and agree on practical actions.

HOW TO USE IT

1. Each organisation completes the statements independently, based on its own perspective and experience.
2. Rate every statement from 1 (Strongly Disagree) to 5 (Strongly Agree).
3. Come together only after both organisations have completed the assessment.
4. For each signal, compare responses, discuss differences, and agree on an action to strengthen the collaboration.

HOW TO READ YOUR SCORES

SCORE	WHAT IT SUGGESTS
4–5 🟢 **Strong foundation**	The condition appears to be well established.
3 🟠 **Emerging**	The condition is developing, but may benefit from further discussion or attention.
1–2 🔴 **Needs Attention**	The condition may need to be strengthened before or during the collaboration.

> *Important: Differences between organisations are often as useful as the scores themselves. Where responses differ significantly, use the discussion questions to understand why.*

SIGNAL 1 OF 5

Shared Curiosity About the Problem

Do we have enough shared understanding of the problem to begin working on it together?

Rate independently

Complete this section separately from the other organisation. Rate each statement from 1 (Strongly Disagree) to 5 (Strongly Agree).

MY ORGANISATION...	SCORE (1–5)
Has invested sufficient time in understanding the problem before discussing potential solutions.	____
Has developed a deeper understanding of the problem through conversations with the other organisation.	____
Has actively explored different perspectives before agreeing on a common problem statement.	____
Has discussed and agreed on a shared definition of the problem we are trying to address.	____

Discuss together

1. Which statements did your organisations score differently? What might explain these differences?

2. What is one thing you could do in the next month to strengthen your shared understanding of the problem?

3. Which stakeholder or perspective is currently missing from your understanding of the problem, and how can you bring it into the conversation?

Action to take

SIGNAL 2 OF 5

Recognition of Complementary Strengths

Do the organisations bring distinct strengths that can create more value together than separately?

Rate independently

Complete this section separately from the other organisation. Rate each statement from 1 (Strongly Disagree) to 5 (Strongly Agree).

MY ORGANISATION...	SCORE (1–5)
Has a clear understanding of the unique and complementary strengths and capabilities that each organisation brings to this collaboration.	____
Believes that the success of this collaboration depends on both organisations contributing their respective strengths.	____
Has intentionally designed the collaboration to make the best use of each organisation's comparative strengths.	____
Has discussed and agreed upon the roles and responsibilities of each organisation.	____

Discuss together

1. Which statements did your organisations score differently? What might explain these differences?
2. Where do you see unnecessary overlap in your roles, and how could responsibilities be better aligned with each organisation's strengths?
3. What changes could you make to ensure that both organisations contribute in ways that neither could achieve independently?

Action to take

SIGNAL 3 OF 5

Leadership Trust

Can the leadership relationship support openness, joint decisions, and difficult conversations when the collaboration is tested?

Rate independently

Complete this section separately from the other organisation. Rate each statement from 1 (Strongly Disagree) to 5 (Strongly Agree).

MY ORGANISATION...	SCORE (1–5)
Is comfortable having open and honest conversations with the other organisation's leadership, including about difficult issues.	____
Has confidence that decisions made by the other organisation's leadership will consider the interests of the collaboration, not just their own organisation.	____
Trusts the leadership of the other organisation to act in good faith, even when challenges or disagreements arise.	____
Believes that our leaders have discussed and agreed on how decisions will be made and disagreements will be resolved during this collaboration.	____

Discuss together

1. Which statements did your organisations score differently? What might explain these differences?

2. What could your leadership teams do differently to strengthen trust and openness between your organisations?

3. What commitments can your leaders make now that will build confidence in this partnership over time?

Action to take

SIGNAL 4 OF 5

A Catalytic Trigger

Is there a compelling reason for the organisations to collaborate now, beyond simply having an opportunity to do so?

Rate independently

Complete this section separately from the other organisation. Rate each statement from 1 (Strongly Disagree) to 5 (Strongly Agree).

MY ORGANISATION...	SCORE (1–5)
Believes this collaboration responds to a shared opportunity or challenge that is timely and important.	____
Would have been interested in exploring a partnership even if this specific opportunity had not arisen.	____
Believes this collaboration aligns with our organisation's longer-term goals and priorities.	____
Has a shared understanding of why this is the right time for our organisations to collaborate.	____

Discuss together

1. Which statements did your organisations score differently? What might explain these differences?

2. If the current project or funding opportunity ended tomorrow, what reasons would remain for your organisations to continue working together?

3. What could you do during this collaboration to build a relationship that extends beyond this immediate opportunity?

Action to take

SIGNAL 5 OF 5

Institutional Capability

Does each organisation have the capacity and internal support needed to sustain the collaboration?

Rate independently

Complete this section separately from the other organisation. Rate each statement from 1 (Strongly Disagree) to 5 (Strongly Agree).

MY ORGANISATION...	SCORE (1–5)
Has partnerships as a key internal priority to explore and manage collaborative initiatives.	____
Has identified the people who will be responsible for coordinating and managing this collaboration.	____
Is willing to adapt our ways of working when needed to support the collaboration.	____
Has the resources and bandwidth to participate meaningfully in this collaboration alongside our existing commitments.	____

Discuss together

1. Which statements did your organisations score differently? What might explain these differences?

2. What organisational constraints could make it difficult for you to collaborate effectively, and how might you address them together?

3. What practical commitment can your organisation make to ensure that the collaboration is adequately supported over time?

Action to take

BRINGING IT TOGETHER

Your Collaboration Readiness Snapshot

Based on your responses and discussion, identify the category that best represents your current position. Use the overall pattern of responses and the discussion, not a mechanical average, to make the choice.

SIGNAL	STRONG	EMERGING	NEEDS ATTENTION
Shared Curiosity About the Problem	○	○	○
Recognition of Complementary Strengths	○	○	○
Leadership Trust	○	○	○
A Catalytic Trigger	○	○	○
Institutional Capability	○	○	○

What does this tell you?

Mostly 🟢 — Strong foundations for collaboration. The enabling conditions are largely in place.

A mix of 🟢 **and** 🟡 — Promising foundations, with some areas requiring attention before or during the collaboration.

One or more 🔴 — The signal needs deliberate attention. This does not mean collaboration is inadvisable; it highlights where conditions may need strengthening.

Reflect together

- Which readiness signals represent your greatest strengths?
- Which signal(s) would benefit most from further attention?
- Where did your organisations have the greatest differences in responses? What might these differences tell you?
- What are the 2–3 things you should strengthen before moving forward?

BEFORE MOVING ON

You have now reflected on whether the conditions for collaboration are in place. The next step is to explore where collaboration is most likely to create value. Not every challenge requires collaboration, and not every collaboration creates value in the same way.

Proceed to **Part 2 — Where Collaboration Creates Value.**



U-CAN
URBAN COLLECTIVE ACTION NETWORK

COLLABORATION TOOLKIT · PART 2

Where Can Collaboration Create Value?

A practical reflection tool for identifying opportunities to unlock value by turning opportunities to action.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

This is Part 2 of the U-CAN Collaboration Toolkit, a comprehensive framework to help organisations build more effective and meaningful collaborations.

If you haven't completed **Part 1 – Are You Ready to Collaborate?**, we recommend starting there. Part 1 helps organisations reflect on whether the conditions for collaboration are in place. This section builds on that foundation.

The goal is not to justify collaboration everywhere, but to identify where collaboration can create value, agree on where to focus, and take the next steps together.

HOW TO USE THIS PART

Not every challenge requires collaboration. This section helps you identify where working together is likely to create greater value than working independently.

1. Each organisation completes the statements independently, based on its own perspective and experience.
2. Rate every statement from 1 (Strongly Disagree) to 5 (Strongly Agree).
3. Come together only after both organisations have completed the assessment.
4. For each scenario, compare responses, discuss differences, and agree on an action.

HOW TO READ YOUR SCORES

PATTERN	WHAT IT SUGGESTS
4–5 🟢 **High value**	A strong case for collaboration in this area.
3 🟠 **Moderate value**	Collaboration may add value, but its role should be clarified.
1–2 🔴 **Low value**	Consider whether working independently or using lighter coordination may be more effective.

> *Important: Differences between organisations are often as useful as the scores themselves. Where responses differ significantly, use the discussion questions to understand why.*

SCENARIO 1 OF 4

Using Complementary Strengths

Can combining our organisations' different strengths create something better than either organisation could achieve alone?

Rate independently

Complete this section separately from the other organisation. Rate each statement from 1 (Strongly Disagree) to 5 (Strongly Agree).

MY ORGANISATION...	SCORE (1–5)
Has identified and articulated how combining our respective strengths could improve the outcomes we are trying to achieve.	____
Has translated an understanding of our respective strengths into specific ways we can address gaps or limitations in our existing approaches.	____
Has identified specific aspects of the work where both organisations could contribute their respective capabilities to strengthen the approach or outcomes.	____
Is prepared to combine its capabilities with those of the other organisation to achieve an outcome that neither could achieve as effectively alone.	____

Discuss together

1. Which statements did your organisations score differently? What might explain these differences?

2. Where could you make better use of each organisation's distinct strengths, and what would that look like in practice?

3. What could you achieve together that would be difficult to achieve independently, and what is the first step towards making it happen?

Action to take

SCENARIO 2 OF 4

Forming a Field View

What could we understand about the field together that we would be unlikely to understand alone?

Rate independently

Complete this section separately from the other organisation. Rate each statement from 1 (Strongly Disagree) to 5 (Strongly Agree).

MY ORGANISATION...	SCORE (1–5)
Has shared perspectives, relationships or information that have expanded the other organisation's understanding of the field.	____
Has worked with the other organisation to map where our respective perspectives, relationships or knowledge provide different views of the wider ecosystem or problem.	____
Has surfaced important stakeholders, perspectives or information that were not previously visible to the other organisation.	____
Has used the other organisation's perspectives, relationships and knowledge to develop a more complete understanding of the field internally.	____

Discuss together

1. Which statements did your organisations score differently? What might explain these differences?

2. Whose perspective or part of the ecosystem is still missing from your understanding, and how could you bring it into the conversation?

3. What could you understand about the field together that you would be unlikely to understand alone, and what could you do to build that shared understanding?

Action to take

SCENARIO 3 OF 4

Setting a Joint Agenda

Can we develop a shared agenda that builds on our areas of convergence while navigating our different priorities, approaches and interests?

Rate independently

Complete this section separately from the other organisation. Rate each statement from 1 (Strongly Disagree) to 5 (Strongly Agree).

MY ORGANISATION...	SCORE (1–5)
Has developed a clear understanding of both organisations' theories of change and how they approach achieving change.	
Has identified where our priorities, approaches and theories of change converge and where they diverge, and what these differences mean for a potential shared agenda.	
Has identified what we are willing to negotiate or compromise on to develop a shared agenda.	
Has a thorough understanding of what our respective stakeholders need from the collaboration and how these interests can be reflected in a shared agenda.	
Has identified where we could align our current programmes, initiatives or resources around a shared agenda to create greater impact.	

Discuss together

1. Which statements did your organisations score differently? What might explain these differences?

2. What are the priorities, theories of change and interests each organisation is bringing to the table? Where do they converge, and where will you need to negotiate differences?

3. What could we achieve through a shared agenda that we would struggle to achieve through parallel efforts?

4. What are we willing to jointly prioritise, compromise on, or leave aside — and what would it take to align our actions around these priorities?

Action to take

SCENARIO 4 OF 4

Experimenting in New Problem Spaces

Are we willing to explore, experiment and learn together where the evidence is insufficient to know what will work?

Rate independently

Complete this section separately from the other organisation. Rate each statement from 1 (Strongly Disagree) to 5 (Strongly Agree).

MY ORGANISATION...	SCORE (1–5)
Recognises that there is significant uncertainty about which approaches are most likely to work in this area.	____
Recognises that existing evidence and experience are insufficient to confidently determine the right approach.	____
Is willing to invest time, effort and resources in exploring and testing new approaches despite this uncertainty.	____
Sees learning and adaptation as important outcomes and indicators of progress in this collaboration, alongside immediate results.	____
Is willing to draw on expertise, experience and perspectives beyond the two organisations to strengthen our experimentation and learning in the new problem space.	____

Discuss together

1. Which statements did your organisations score differently? What might explain these differences?

2. What uncertainties are you trying to reduce, and what could you learn together that you could not learn alone?

3. How could you design the collaboration so that learning from what does not work is as valuable as learning from what does?

Action to take

BRINGING IT TOGETHER

Your Collaboration Opportunity Snapshot

After discussing each scenario, identify the opportunities where collaboration appears most likely to create value. Use the overall pattern of responses and your discussion, not a mechanical average.

OPPORTUNITY	HIGH	MODERATE	LOW
Using Complementary Strengths	○	○	○
Forming a Field View	○	○	○
Setting a Joint Agenda	○	○	○
Experimenting in New Problem Spaces	○	○	○

What does this tell you?

Mostly 🟢 — There is a strong case for collaboration in these areas. Focus your joint effort where working together can create value that would be difficult to achieve independently.

A mix of 🟢 **and** 🟡 — Collaboration is likely to add value in some areas more than others. Focus your effort where the case for collaboration is strongest.

Mostly 🟡 **or one or more** 🔴 — The role of collaboration is less clear in these areas. Consider whether a lighter form of coordination — or working independently — may be more effective.

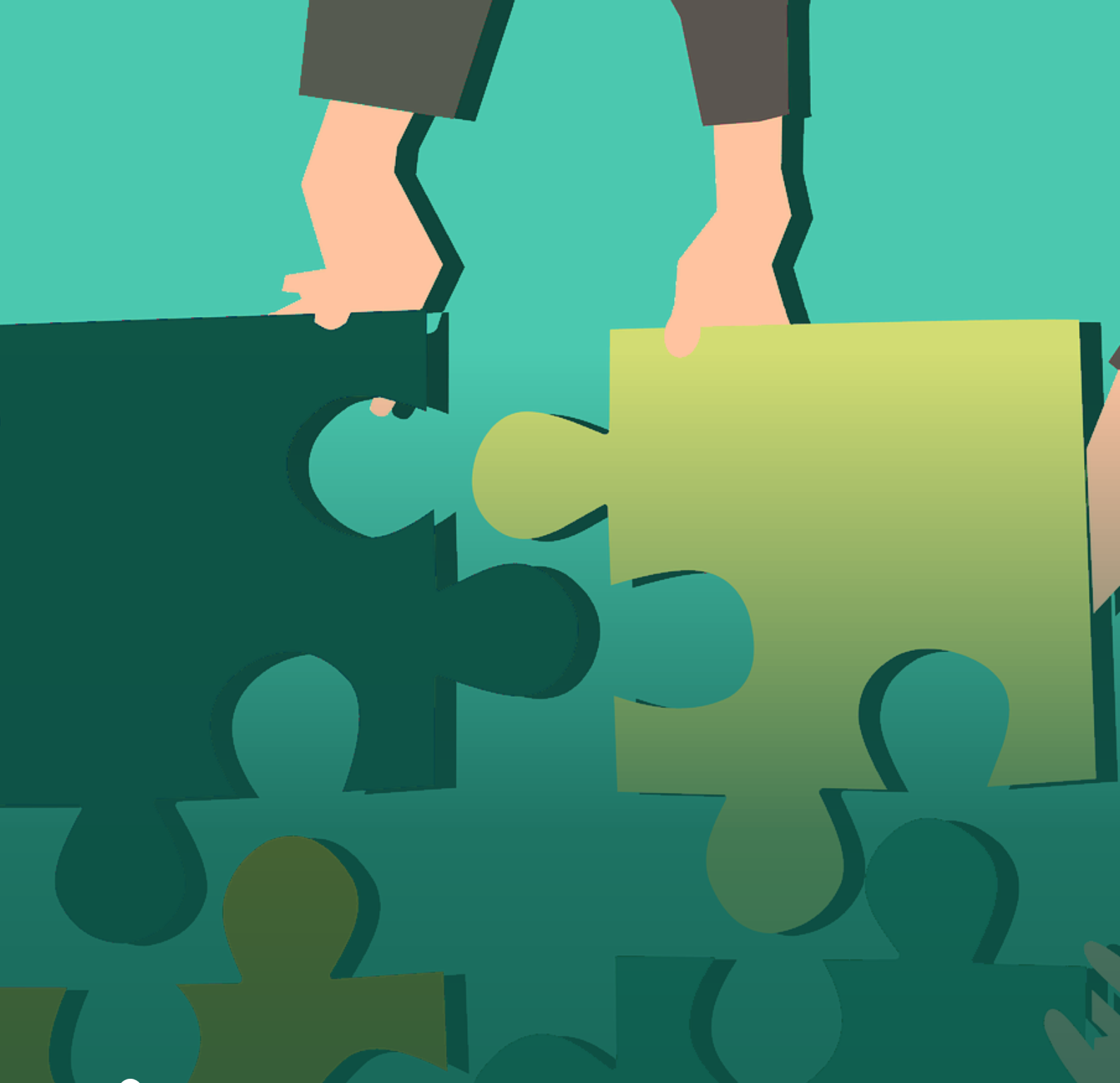
Reflect together

1. Which opportunity presents the strongest case for collaboration?
2. Which opportunities may be better pursued independently or through lighter coordination?
3. What should be the primary focus of this collaboration?

BEFORE MOVING ON

You have now reflected on where collaboration is most likely to create value. The next step is to focus on how to collaborate effectively. Successful collaboration requires intentional ways of working, regular reflection, and the ability to adapt over time.

Proceed to **Part 3 — Navigating the Collaboration Journey.**



U-CAN
URBAN COLLECTIVE ACTION NETWORK

COLLABORATION TOOLKIT · PART 3

Navigating the Collaboration Journey

A practical reflection tool for navigating collaboration as it evolves

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

This is Part 3 of the U-CAN Collaboration Toolkit, a comprehensive framework to help organisations understand, navigate and strengthen collaboration.

Parts 1 and 2 helped you assess whether you are ready to collaborate and where collaboration can create value. Part 3 focuses on what happens once you begin working together: how the collaboration evolves, where it may need attention, and what you can do to strengthen it.

Collaboration is rarely linear. Organisations may move between stages, revisit earlier stages, or experience several stages at once. The purpose of this section is therefore not to move through the stages in sequence, but to identify what the collaboration needs at different points in its journey.

HOW TO USE THIS SECTION

Collaboration is not a linear process. Organisations may move between stages, revisit earlier stages, or experience several stages at once. Use this section at regular moments to reflect on how the collaboration is evolving and what it needs next.

The stages are not a fixed sequence, and therefore this part is designed to be used slightly differently. First, review the four stages and identify which stage, or stages, are most relevant to the collaboration right now, and then follow the following steps:

1. Each organisation completes the statements independently, based on its own perspective and experience.
2. Rate every statement from 1 (Strongly Disagree) to 5 (Strongly Agree).
3. Come together only after both organisations have completed the assessment.
4. For each scenario, compare responses, discuss differences, and agree on an action.

> *Return to these questions as the collaboration evolves. You may move between stages or revisit an earlier one based on how your collaboration evolves.*

THE FOUR STAGES

STAGE	WHAT IT IS ABOUT
1. Idea Incubation	Exploring ideas together without pressure to formalise.
2. Ways of Working	Agreeing how the organisations will work together.
3. Joint Execution	Doing the work together and navigating differences.
4. Value Creation	Making visible what the collaboration has created and changed.

> *Note: These stages are not a checklist or a fixed sequence. The journey is relational, iterative and shaped by what organisations learn along the way.*

HOW TO READ YOUR SCORES

PATTERN	WHAT IT SUGGESTS
4–5 🟢 Strong	The collaboration appears to be working well in this area.
3 🟠 Emerging	There is some foundation, but this area may need further attention or clarification.
1–2 🔴 Needs attention	This area may be creating challenges for the collaboration and would benefit from focused attention.

> *Remember: The scores are not a measure of whether the collaboration is "good" or "bad". They are a way to surface differences and identify where a conversation or action may be useful.*

STAGE 1 OF 4

Idea Incubation

Are we giving the idea enough space to develop before formalising it?

Rate independently

Complete this section separately from the other organisation. Rate each statement from 1 (Strongly Disagree) to 5 (Strongly Agree).

MY ORGANISATION...	SCORE (1–5)
Is able to explore the problem and possible ideas without pressure to arrive at a fixed solution.	____
Is giving the other organisation enough space to introduce ideas, questions or perspectives that may change the direction of the work.	____
Is using conversations with the other organisation to question and refine our initial assumptions about the opportunity.	____

Discuss together

1. Which statements did your organisations score differently? What do these differences suggest you need to explore or clarify together?

2. What have you learned through your conversations that has changed how you see the opportunity?

3. Are you moving towards formalisation because the idea is ready, or because there is pressure to act?

4. What might you lose by formalising the collaboration too quickly?

Action to take

STAGE 2 OF 4

Ways of Working

Have we created enough clarity about how we will work together without making the collaboration too rigid?

Rate independently

Complete this section separately from the other organisation. Rate each statement from 1 (Strongly Disagree) to 5 (Strongly Agree).

MY ORGANISATION...	SCORE (1–5)
Has sufficient clarity on roles and responsibilities while retaining flexibility to adapt as the collaboration evolves.	____
Has agreed with the other organisation on communication rhythms and how decisions will be made.	____
Team members know what they can decide independently and what needs to be discussed across organisations.	____

Discuss together

1. Which statements did your organisations score differently? What do these differences suggest you need to clarify or work through together?
2. Where are expectations about roles, responsibilities or ways of working still unclear?
3. What do our teams need from each other to work effectively?
4. Where might our existing organisational processes create friction, and how can we work around them?

Action to take

STAGE 3 OF 4

Joint Execution

Are we using differences between our organisations as a source of learning rather than allowing them to become barriers?

Rate independently

Complete this section separately from the other organisation. Rate each statement from 1 (Strongly Disagree) to 5 (Strongly Agree).

MY ORGANISATION...	SCORE (1–5)
Is adapting its ways of working as we learn from the experience of working together.	____
Is using disagreements and friction as opportunities to learn and improve the work.	____
Is willing and able to revisit assumptions when the experience of working together challenges them.	____

Discuss together

1. Which statements did your organisations score differently? What do these differences suggest you need to surface or work through together?
2. What differences between your organisations are creating friction right now?
3. Which of these differences could become a source of learning or value?
4. What would help you address friction openly before it affects the relationship or the work?

Action to take

STAGE 4 OF 4

Value Creation

What value is the collaboration creating, and what will remain after the collaboration ends?

Rate independently

Complete this section separately from the other organisation. Rate each statement from 1 (Strongly Disagree) to 5 (Strongly Agree).

MY ORGANISATION...	SCORE (1–5)
Is able to see outcomes or changes that would have been difficult for either organisation to achieve alone.	____
Is capturing learning and changes in capabilities, relationships or ways of working alongside tangible outputs.	____
Has identified relationships, capabilities or practices that we want to carry into future work.	____

Discuss together

1. Which statements did your organisations score differently? What do these differences suggest you need to explore or make more visible together?
2. What has the collaboration created that neither organisation could have created alone?
3. What changes in people, capabilities, relationships or ways of working are emerging?
4. What should you carry forward, change or stop as the collaboration evolves?

Action to take

BRINGING IT TOGETHER

Your Collaboration Journey Learnings

Use this page after reflecting on the stages of your collaboration. Capture the practices, behaviours and lessons you want to remember the next time your organisation works with another organisation.

STAGE	WHAT DID WE DO RIGHT THIS TIME THAT WE SHOULD MAKE AN ORGANISATIONAL PRACTICE GOING FORWARD?	WHAT WILL WE DO DIFFERENTLY NEXT TIME?
Idea Incubation		
Ways of Working		
Joint Execution		
Value Creation		

BEFORE MOVING ON

Every collaboration can strengthen an organisation's ability to collaborate in the future. The purpose of this reflection is to capture what this experience taught you — not just about the work, but about how your organisation works with others.

Carry these lessons forward when you begin your next collaboration.